

PROJECT REPORT

THE SIMS PRIORITY GAP

Did The Sims 4 Forget How to Simulate Life?
10+ Years of Data Says Yes

Full Project Available on [GitHub](#) | Dashboard Available on [Tableau](#)

Author	Project Type	Tools	Completion Date
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1. Introduction

The Sims 4 is a life simulation game where players create and control characters called Sims, guiding them through careers, relationships, families, and everyday life. For a game like this to deliver on its premise, it needs depth. Afterall, the whole point of a life simulation is that it simulates real life.

Between 2014 and March 2026, EA released 98 paid DLC packs ranging from \$39.99 Expansion Packs to \$4.99 Kits. Over that same period, a consistent theme kept coming up in the player community, which was that paid content was becoming more about visuals than actual simulation depth. I decided to use data to find out if that feeling was backed up by the numbers.

The central question is this: Across 98 packs released between 2014 and 2026, what proportion was Simulation-Rich versus Aesthetic, and how did that change over time?

2. Methodology

Dataset 1: DLC Master Log:

I manually catalogued all 98 packs using EA's official Sims 4 website and the Sims Wiki. For every pack, I recorded the name, pack type (Expansion Pack, Game Pack, Stuff Pack, or Kit), release date, release year, launch price in USD, free status, my Simulation-Rich vs. Aesthetic classification and the Primary impact on simulation.

Here is how I classified each pack:

- **Simulation-Rich:** Does the pack introduce a new mechanic, life stage, or career that changes how the game actually functions? If yes, it is Simulation-Rich.
- **Aesthetic:** Does it just add new items like clothes, furniture, or décor? If removing all the new items would leave the game playing exactly the same, it is Aesthetic.

Packs with both elements were classified by whichever was the dominant purpose. Judgement calls that were made are documented in the Primary Impact column of the DLC Master Log Sheet in the Excel workbook.

Data Validation:

Because all data was entered manually, I took several steps to make sure the numbers are reliable. I cross-referenced pack names and prices across the Sims Wiki and EA's official store to confirm consistency. I used Excel's Conditional formatting to visually flag any blank cells so that missing data would be immediately obvious. I manually reviewed the Content Category column using filters to check for any inconsistent entries before finalizing the dataset. Finally, I ran checks at the end of every sheet: the total pack count must equal to 98, the total DLC retail value must equal to \$1,508.02, and the Kit count must show zero for every year before 2021. Any check that failed got traced back to the source before I moved on.

Exclusions and Rationale:

Excluded Item	Reason
Base Game	A required purchase, not optional DLC. The \$59.99 base game price is recorded separately and only included in the Total Cost to Own figure. It is not part of the DLC retail value split
Creator Kits	Designed by community creators, not EA's internal team. They do not reflect EA's own content strategy decisions
Holiday Celebration Pack	A free promotional release used as a marketing tool, not a paid commercial content decision.
DLC Bundles	These are existing packs grouped together at discounted prices. Including them would count the same content twice.
Sims 3 Store Premium Worlds	Sold using SimsPoints virtual currency, not direct USD pricing. A different monetization model that cannot be fairly compared with the rest of the dataset.
Free Base Game Updates	Not paid content, so they fall outside the scope of this DLC analysis. They are referenced in the Feature and Cost Comparison sheet to show what EA delivered for free versus what required a paid purchase.

Dataset 2: Community-Requested Features Log:

I catalogued 17 simulation features based on how consistently they appeared across EA Forums, Reddit (r/Sims4, and r/thesims), and YouTube video reviews and comment sections. The Earliest Verified Request date is the oldest post, thread, or article I found during research. This does not mean it was the first time the feature was ever requested, only the earliest source I could verify.

Each feature was assigned a delivery status: Never Added, Added Late, or Partially Added. I also calculated a Years Ignored figure using this formula: =IF(D2="Never Added", Year(TODAY())-C2,IF(D2="Partially Added", YEAR(TODAY())-C2,E2-C2)).

Dataset 3: Competitor Feature Comparison:

I compared 23 simulation features across 6 game versions: The Sims 3 Launch (2009), The Sims 4 Launch (2014), The Sims 4 Base Game Now (2026), The Sims 4 Full Game (2026), inZOI (2025) during Early access, and Paralives as anticipated during Early Access (2026). Each cell was marked YES, NO, or PARTIAL based on official descriptions and verified press coverage.

A Note on Retail Value:

All figures labelled as retail value in this project represent the combined launch prices of DLC packs (what a player would have paid purchasing each pack individually at the time of release). These are not EA's earnings. EA does not publicly disclose DLC sales data. All retail value figures in this project are from the buyer's perspective only.

Excel Tools Used:

Across the analysis sheets, I used:

- COUNTIFS and SUMIFS for counting packs and calculating retail value by category and pack type.
- IFERROR to handle division errors in years with zero packs released.
- Cumulative formula logic to build the running retail value totals year by year.
- PIVOT Tables with Slicers for the interactive pack type breakdown.
- Conditional Formatting to apply colour coding to the Feature and Cost Comparison sheet (green for YES, red for NO, yellow for PARTIAL) to flag data entry issues during validation.

Limitations

Limitation	Explanation
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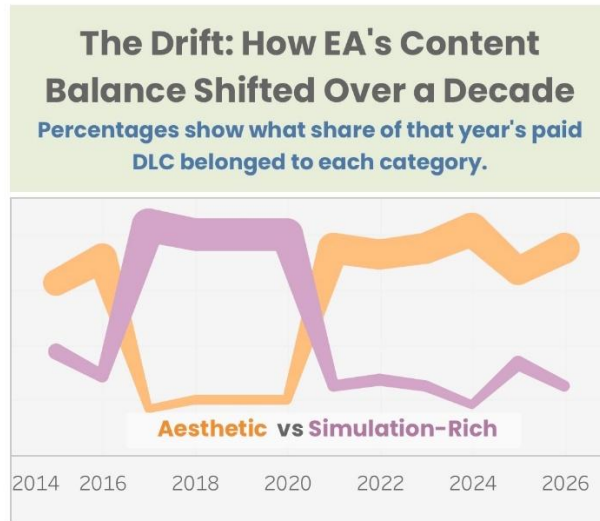
No actual sales data	EA does not publicly disclose unit sales figures. All retail value figures represent launch prices only, not what EA actually earned.
Classification Subjectivity	Some packs were genuinely difficult to classify. Judgement calls that were made are documented in the Primary Impact column of the DLC Master Log Sheet in the Excel workbook.
Competitor data accuracy	InZOI and Paralives are not fully released yet. Their features may still change before or after full launch.
Historical pricing	Prices were cross-referenced from the Sims Wiki, EA Store, Reddit, and gaming news sites. Older prices may not be perfectly accurate if those sources have since been updated.
Community request dates	Based on the oldest sources I could find during research. Players may have been requesting some features even earlier than what I was able to document.

3. Finding 1: The Content Split

Out of all 98 paid DLC packs released between 2014 and 2026, 60 packs (61.2%) are classified as Aesthetic and 38 packs (38.8%) are classified as Simulation-Rich. That means more than three out of every five paid packs released over this decade were primarily visual (aesthetic) in nature.

To see how that split played out year by year, open the Tableau dashboard and look at The Drift (The dual line chart in the top left). The orange line shows the percentage of Aesthetic releases each year and the purple line shows Simulation-Rich. What stands out is that between 2017 and 2020, the purple Simulation-Rich line actually rises above the orange line. During those four years, EA was releasing proportionally more Simulation-Rich content.

That four-year window matters because it shows the overall 61.2% Aesthetic split is not simply how this game has always operated. There was a period when the balance genuinely tilted toward simulation-depth. Something changed after 2020; Aesthetic content represented over 70% of all releases (except 2025 where it fell to 66.67%), peaking at 81.82% in 2024.



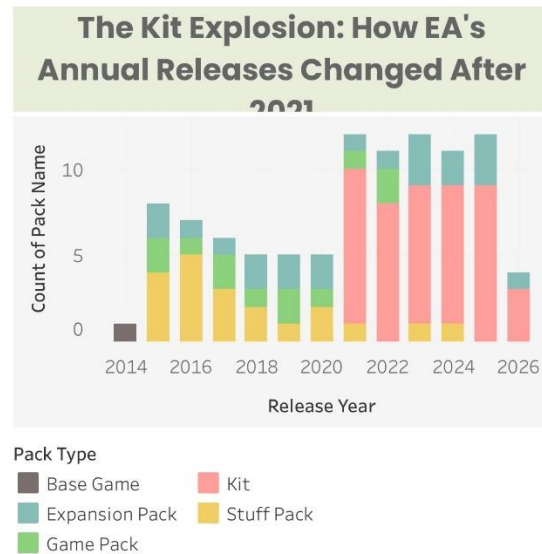
4. Finding 2: The Kit Effect

In March 2021, EA introduced a new pack type called Kits. Priced at \$4.99 (with the exception of two SpongeBob-themed Kits priced at \$6.99 each), each Kit contains around ten clothing or furniture items with little to no gameplay systems attached. Every Kit, with the exception of Restoration Workshop and Bust the Dust, released to date, classifies as Aesthetic under this project's rubric.

To see the impact look at **The Kit Explosion** (the stacked bar chart second from the left in the top row of the dashboard). Every bar before 2021 is made up of only Expansion Packs (blue), Game Packs (green), and Stuff Packs (yellow). There is no pink anywhere. Then from 2021 onwards, pink segments appear and make up the largest single portion of each bar.

Year	Expansion Packs	Game Packs	Stuff Packs	Kits	Total
2021	1	1	1	9	12
2022	1	2	0	8	11
2023	3	0	1	8	12
2024	2	0	1	8	11
2025	3	0	0	9	12
Up to March 2026	1	0	0	3	4
Total	11	3	3	45	62

Kits now account for 45 of 98 packs (45.9%) of the entire catalogue, released across just four years.



5. Finding 3: The Retail Value Picture

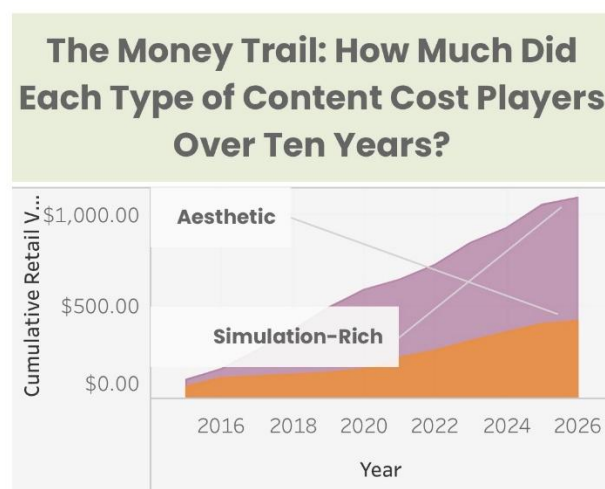
Looking at retail value by category, the cumulative total for all Aesthetic DLC comes to \$418.40 and the cumulative total for all Simulation-Rich DLC comes to \$1,089.62. Before drawing any conclusions from those numbers, it is important to understand why the Simulation-Rich total is higher.

To see this, look at **The Money Trail** (the stacked area chart in the middle left of the dashboard). The purple area represents Simulation-Rich retail value building up year over year and the orange represents Aesthetic. The purple area is taller throughout the chart but that is a price difference not a volume difference. Expansion Packs cost \$39.99 each while Kits cost \$4.99. One Expansion Pack costs eight times more than one Kit.

So why would EA choose to release cheaper Kits instead of more expensive Expansion Packs? The answer is in the volume. Even though each Kit only costs \$4.99, releasing 45 of them in four years generates enough cumulative retail value to remain commercially significant, without the development time and investment that a full Expansion Pack requires. EA found a way to keep retail value flowing from players through high frequency, low-cost visual content rather than investing in the deeper, more expensive gameplay releases.

In other words, instead of selling you one \$39.99 game expansion, they found they could sell you eight \$4.99 clothing packs and get close to the same amount with far less effort. The data shows the strategy in action: the orange Aesthetic area on the chart accelerates sharply after 2021, driven by the sheer number of releases.

The turning point is visible in 2021. That was the first year in which the yearly Aesthetic retail value exceeded the yearly Simulation-Rich retail value (\$59.91 versus \$54.97). It was the first calendar year where visual-only packs collectively cost players more in a single year than gameplay packs did.

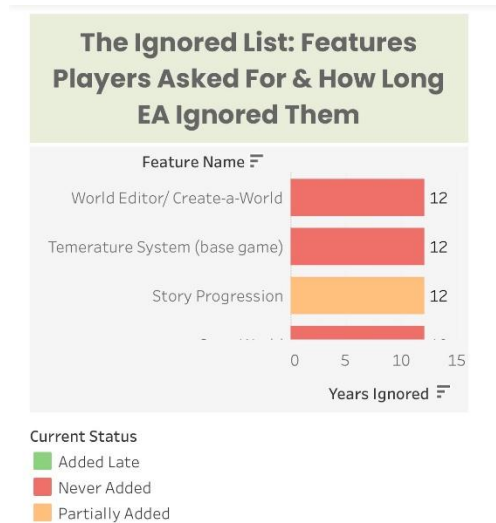


6. Finding 4: The Ignored Features

To see this finding, look at **The Ignored List** (the horizontal bar chart in the middle section of the dashboard). Each bar represents a simulation feature that kept appearing across EA Answers HQ, Reddit, and YouTube. The length of the bar shows how many years that feature went unaddressed. Red means **Never Added**, yellow means **Partially Added**, and green means **Added Late**.

Of the 17 features I tracked, 11 with High or Medium impact ratings have been appearing in community sources since 2014. Three noteworthy red bars, all reaching 12 years, are Open World, Color Wheel/Recolor Tool, and Drivable Cars are all present in The Sims 3, released by the same developer in 2009. All 3 are still marked NO in the Sims 4 Full Game column, even with every single pack purchased.

It is worth noting what the green bars show too. Toddlers were added through a free update in 2017. Burglars were added through a free update in 2025 after 11 years. These confirm that simulation additions to the base game are possible. The Ignored List simply documents the features where that still has not happened.



7. Finding 5: The Ownership Cost

To see this finding, look at **The Dollar Question** (the lollipop chart in the middle top right of the dashboard). Each lollipop represents one game. The height of the thin vertical line shows the total cost to own at launch prices, and the circle at the top is sized by the number of DLC packs. The Sims 4 Full Game is highlighted in green.

Game	Base Game	Total DLC	Total Cost	DLC Packs
The Sims 3 (2009)	\$49.99	\$609.80	\$659.79	Approx. 20
The Sims 4 Launch (2014)	\$59.99	\$0.00	\$59.99	0
The Sims 4 Full Game (2026)	\$59.99	\$1,508.02	\$1,568.01	98
inZOI (2025)	\$39.99	\$0.00	\$39.99	0
Paralives (anticipated 2026)	\$39.99	\$0.00	\$39.99	0

The Sims 4 Full Game sits at \$1,568.01, which is 2.38 times the total cost of owning all of The Sims 3, which launched with more simulation features than The Sims 4 base game. And that is for a game that became free-to-play in 2022, meaning new players can start for nothing but are expected to spend over \$1,500 to access the full experience. All figures are based on individual launch prices. Sales prices and bundles are excluded to keep the comparison consistent across all titles.



8. Finding 6: The Feature Gap

To see this finding, look at **The Feature Gap** (the heat map running the full width of the bottom of the dashboard). Each row is a simulation feature grouped by category: World and Navigation, Build Mode, Life Simulation, Careers and Education, and Pets. Each column is one of the six game versions. Green means YES (this feature is present), red means NO (this feature is absent), and yellow means PARTIAL (a limited version exists).

Use the Feature Type Filter beside the chart and select Core only. With that filter applied, the Sims 4 Launch (2014) column becomes almost entirely red (**NO** on 7 out of 8 Core features). The only YES is the Careers System. The Sims 3 Launch (2009) column, placed directly next to it, shows **YES** on 7 of those same 8 Core features.

To put that plainly; a player who bought The Sims 4 at launch for \$59.99 in 2014 got a game that was missing more Core simulation features than The Sims 3 had already included back in 2009 ...at a \$10 higher base price.

With all 98 DLC packs purchased, The Sims 4 Full Game column improves significantly, but Open World, Color Wheen/Recolor Tool, Driveable Cars, Spiral Staircases, World Editor/Create-a-World, and Weather/Seasons as a base game feature are all still marked NO, even in the fully equipped version.

The Feature Gap: Does Each Game Have The Features a Life Simulator Should?

Use the filter to select 'Core' features only and see what EA launched without in 2014

Feature Name	The Sims 3 (2009)
Terrain Tools	
Active Careers	
Careers System	
University	
Attraction System	
Burglars/Danger Mechanics	

Feature Type
(All)

Availability

 NO  PARTIAL  YES

9. Conclusion

Six separate lines of analysis were run on this data: the overall content split, the Kit effect on annual release patterns, the retail value picture over time, the community-requested features that remain unaddressed, the total ownership cost compared to competitors, and the simulation feature availability across game versions. All six point in the same direction.

61.2% of paid DLC is Aesthetic. The proportion grew significantly after Kits launched in 2021 (over 70% in almost every year since). Aesthetic packs dominate by volume while Simulation-Rich carry higher individual retail value. Features requested in community sources since 2014 are still unaddressed in 2026. Full ownership costs \$1,568.01. The Sims 4 at launch was missing 7 out of 8 Core simulation features compared to its predecessor.

The data answers the central question clearly: EA's paid content strategy shifted away from simulation depth and toward high-volume visual content, and that shift accelerated significantly after 2021.

10. Strategic Implications For EA

Here is the part that matters: The Sims 4 is sold as a life simulation game; that's one of the main reasons people buy it. They want to do all the things they do in everyday life in the game. The whole point of a life simulation game is that the simulation gets richer, more complex, and more meaningful over time. When 61.2% of a decade's worth of paid content is visual add-ons and 45.9% of the entire catalogue is \$4.99 clothing and furniture packs, the game is selling the packaging of a life simulator without consistently delivering the depth one expects.

From a commercial perspective, the Kit strategy makes sense on the surface. Kits are faster to produce, they are cheap enough that players do not think too hard before buying, and releasing 9 to 10 per year keeps the store looking active. Even at \$4.99 per unit, 45 Kits in four years adds up. EA found a way to keep retail value coming in at a lower production cost than a full Expansion Pack. That is a rational short-term business decision.

But here is what the data exposes about the trade-off: **it works only as long as players have no better option**. The simulation features missing from The Sims 4 (Open World, a Color Wheel, driveable cars), are not missing because they are impossible to build. Afterall, The Sims 3 had them in 2009. The question this data raises is whether something else explains the gap. When you look at the competitor column in the Feature Gap chart and see inZOI launching with all those features in its base game at \$39.99, that question becomes harder to set aside.

On the Aesthetic Content Argument:

To be objective, it is worth asking whether EA is simply giving players what they want. Without access to EA's actual sales data, it is not possible to confirm which pack types sell best. However, there are observable signals. The Sims Gallery (EA's in-game platform where players share their creations) is visibly dominated by build mode and Create-a-Sim content rather than gameplay stories. On YouTube, Build and CAS-focused videos consistently attract large audiences. These signals suggest that a real and active market for Aesthetic content exists within the player base.

This project does not argue that Aesthetic content has no value or that players do not enjoy it. The argument is that the balance shifted significantly, and the players who specifically want a deeper life simulator (the ones the franchise was built for), have seen the Simulation-Rich share of the catalogue shrink year over year. Those two groups are not mutually exclusive, and the recommendations below are written with both in mind.

11. Recommendations

The Kit strategy has kept the store moving but that data shows it is creating a gap between what the game is sold as and what it actually delivers. That gap is now being filled by competitors.

1. Competition Is No Longer a Future Problem

For most of its life, The Sims 4 had no real competition in this genre but that changed in 2025. inZOI launched with the features The Sims community has been asking for since 2014 (open world, driveable cars, color customization) all in the base game, at \$39.99, with no paid DLC at launch. Paralives is anticipated to follow a similar model. These are direct alternatives targeting the same audience The Sims franchise has built over decades.

A player comparing their options today sees a game that costs \$1,568.01 to fully own and still does not include features a competitor just launched with for free. That is a value proposition that gets harder to defend the more established those alternatives become.

2. After 12 Years, Players/ Patience Is Running Out

Open World, Color Wheel and Driveable Cars are not edge case requests from a small corner of the internet. They appear in EA's own feedback forum. Infact, wherever The Sims 4 is being discussed online, those features always appear. Any business must understand that loyalty to a brand only lasts as long as the brand is making a reasonable effort to meet the audience halfway. The Ignored List in this project documents that effort, and 12 years of the same red bars is hard data to argue against.

The players who stay for depth will eventually go where the depth is, while the players who stay for Aesthetics will follow the aesthetics wherever EA takes them. The question is which group the franchise wants to be built on long term, and if a competitor can offer both simulation depth and Aesthetics (all at a lower price), what will happen to EA's customer base?

3. What a Rebalanced Strategy Looks Like

The goal is not to eliminate Kits, they have an audience and a business case. The goal is to restore enough Simulation-Rich output that the franchise continues to justify its identity and its price tag.

- **Bring back a Simulation-Rich floor:** Between 2017 and 2020, EA averaged 2 to 3 Simulation-Rich packs per year alongside other releases. The data shows this is achievable. Returning to that pace, even while Kits continue, would begin to reverse the imbalance without disrupting the current release structure.
- **Use free updates to close the Core feature gap:** EA has already shown this is possible with Toddles in 2017 and Burglars in 2025. Delivering one long-requested Core feature through a free update sends a clear signal that the simulation identity of the franchise still matters. Given that competitors are launching with those features built in, this is now a competitive necessity rather than a community goodwill gesture.
- **Reconnect the price to the experience:** Charging \$1,568.01 for a life simulator that lacks features its predecessor had in 2009 is a gap that players and competitors notice. Closing even part of that gap is what makes the product worth the price where alternatives are entering at a fraction of the cost.

History has shown, across every industry, that even the most loyal customer base will eventually move on when a competitor consistently offers more for less. The Sims 4 is not immune to that reality. The simulation features players have been asking for since 2014 are now available from competitors at a lower price point.

The data cannot predict exactly when EA will feel the impact of this shift, but it can confirm that the conditions for it are already in place. Therefore, the window to act is now, while the audience is still here and engaged. A course correction today is a fraction of the cost of rebuilding a player base that has already left.

10. What I Learned

Skills I Improved/Developed

- COUNTIFS, SUMIFS, and IFERROR formula logic in Excel
- Pivot table construction with Slicers for interactive filtering
- Conditional Formatting in Excel for data validation and the Feature and Cost Comparison Visual
- Dual-axis chart building in Tableau
- Heat map construction with manual colour assignment and interactive Feature Type filters
- Dashboard layout and design for non-technical audience

What Was Harder Than Expected

- Building the Feature Data sheet in long format across 138 rows was slow and error-prone. One spelling inconsistency in a game name created a duplicate column in Tableau that took time to trace back to the source.
- The lollipop chart required relearning the dual-axis technique before the chart type even made visual sense.
- Keeping the Aesthetic vs. Simulation-Rich classification consistent across 98 packs meant returning to the rubric repeatedly to avoid drift, especially for Game Packs with mixed content.

What I Would Do Differently

- Save direct links to specific forum threads, Reddit posts, and YouTube videos from the start rather than noting just the general source. This would make community request dates more verifiable.

The most useful thing data analysis can do is to give a clear answer to something people already sense but haven't been able to prove. The findings here will not surprise anyone who has followed The Sims 4 community over the past decade.

Technical Note:

All data collection, analysis, and conclusions within this project were performed by the author. Generative AI was used as an editorial tool to refine the tone and readability of the written reports, ensuring the findings are accessible to audiences of all backgrounds.